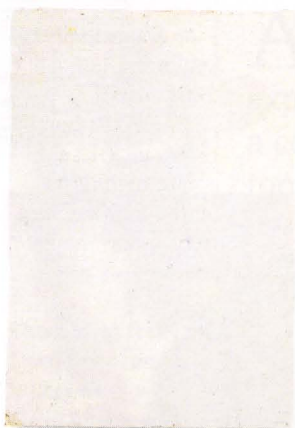


WORKING WITH A PAINTING KNIFE



Textured surfaces

A painting knife produces a variety of interesting textural effects simply by being held in different ways. If you want to increase the degree of texture on the surface of your support, mix some dry sand into the primer when you prepare the board. This builds up the surface of the support into a relief, pushing the painting into three dimensions.



IF YOU ARE UNACCUSTOMED to working with a painting knife, the first thing that will strike you is how different the paint feels on a knife compared to a brush. Working with a painting knife

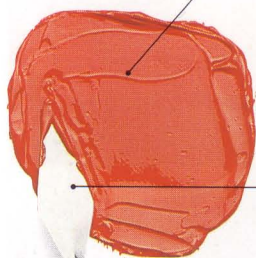
requires some delicacy, as it spreads the paint like butter

onto bread; the flat surface of the painting knife seems to slice easily through the paint as you lay it onto the canvas. A paintbrush tends to come down onto the canvas vertically, while the painting knife can be applied horizontally, parallel to the surface of the painting. Painting knife studies are often made wet-in-wet, generally using more opaque colors.

Using a painting knife

A painting knife needs to be used with confidence and without hesitation, so it is worth practicing first. Use a knife both for building up final highlights in thick impasto and for a textured, lively painting. Painting knives are not the same as palette knives, which are only intended for mixing paint and cleaning palettes; painting knives have a bend in the handle so that they can be held in several different ways to manipulate the creamy paint into expressive shapes (*see below*). Many artists use their finger on the springy blade, pushing it down deliberately to control the way the paint is applied. Since paint is usually applied very thickly with a painting knife, it is sensible to work on a rigid support.

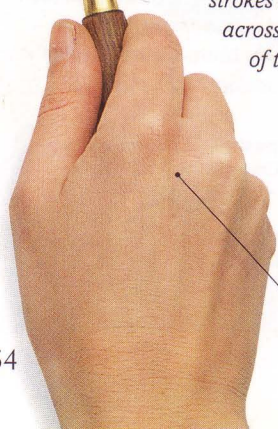
Horizontal strokes of thick, creamy paint from a loaded painting knife.



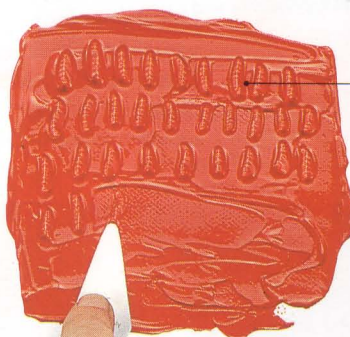
Use the length of the blade to smear paint over a surface.

Bold strokes

Grip the handle firmly, as you would a trowel, and paint decisive, vigorous strokes of color across the surface of the support.



Wrap your fingers firmly around the wooden handle.



Small dabs of color are useful for details.

Press gently into the paint with a finger on the back of the blade.



Light effects

For a lighter control of the painting knife, place your index finger on the springy part of the blade so that just the tip presses down into the paint.



Use this technique to build up a regular pattern of texture.

A firm but even grip gives good control.



Clean lines

A more common way of holding the knife is to place your index finger on the end of the wooden handle and push the metal shaft into the paint. This produces a firm imprint of the blade in the paint and is useful for making ridged lines of color.